

PAUL'S LAST LETTER

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For about 18 months, during our Wednesday night zoom Bible study, we have been covering the writings and journeys of the apostle Paul. We tend to study not just what was said and written, but the background story of each letter.

The background history is fascinating and sheds new light on the words penned by Paul under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit.

Recently, we finished the last letter that the apostle Paul wrote in 2 Timothy. After having a better understanding of what was happening when Paul wrote his last book, before being executed, it brings the book alive in a new way.

Paul wrote about half of the books in the New Testament. He was an amazing man, to say the least. Paul had many fascinating experiences. He saw miracles and the hand of God displayed with might and power. Paul had a unique gift. He would pray over handkerchiefs or cloths and they would be taken to the sick, who would find healing in the touch of these anointed materials on their bodies (Acts 19:11-12).

And yet Paul also saw dark days. He was beaten, stoned, left for dead, shipwrecked, and at the end of his life, he felt the pain of loneliness after being abandoned by many of his companions. Yet, Paul had kept close to him his faithful companions who ministered to him at his very last hours in a dark, dingy, smelly prison in Rome.

In 1 Timothy, Paul wrote to Timothy as he left him in Ephesus (a town

located in modern-day Turkey), to oversee the growing number of faithful followers in Ephesus. Paul later wrote to Titus, after leaving Titus on the island of Crete, and charged him to set things in order by ordaining elders in each city as the Holy Spirit indicated.

1 and 2 Timothy, along with Titus, are known as the "pastoral epistles." These are the only three books in the New Testament written primarily to the shepherds, or elders of the local churches, and they are full of clear instructions and qualifications for elders and deacons in Paul's day, and in our day.

The chronological order of Paul's writing is this: 1 Timothy, Titus, 2 Timothy. You will find a change in the tone of the epistle when Paul pens 2 Timothy as compared to 1 Timothy and Titus.

2 Timothy finds Paul in a prison in the center of the "eternal city" of Rome. It is a prison that was once a water cistern. It was perhaps eighteen feet in diameter. Paul was most likely lowered into the prison from the hole in the ceiling where the guards could look down at Paul. There was no escaping. This prison was most often used as the last place of incarceration, a type of holding tank where prisoners awaited execution. It is written that Peter was also held in this prison before his execution, as well as at another time.

On the outside, this was a dark time for Paul. It was Paul's darkest hour. About three years previous to his last letter, the Roman ruler Vespasian, placed Jerusalem under siege by the Roman Empire to stop the Jews

who were fighting for their own independence. Many of the Christians of Jerusalem had fled to other countries to escape persecution and death.

Paul wrote his last letter about 67 AD, three years after Vespasian had started the military action against Jerusalem. In three short years (70 AD), the holiest site in all of Israel, the Temple, would be destroyed by General Titus, just as Jesus prophesied in Matthew 24.

This would be the beginning of the Diaspora. Two thousand years would pass with the Jews cast from their own land, and no land to claim as their own. However, God brought them back just as He promised in Ezekiel 37, which was known as a super miracle.

Paul was placed in this dimly lit prison, most likely the Mamertine prison of Rome that sits near the center of Rome's glorious Palatine hills and the ancient forum. Because it was a nondescript prison made from an old underground water cistern, it was difficult to even find. My wife and I visited this cell in person in Rome. With all of the ancient and well-published sites of Rome, it was still difficult for us to find this abandoned prison.

Paul notes in 2 Timothy that his good friend Onesiphorus sought to find him while there. *"He (Onesiphorus) searched for me earnestly and found me"* Paul said in 2 Timothy 1:17. In other words, his prison was not easy to find. Paul writes to Timothy and asks him to please come before winter and bring along his "cloak." In other words, Paul was saying, in essence, "Please come before it gets really cold here, and bring my cloak, because I am very cold." The Romans were not known for supplying comforts to condemned prisoners.

There was another man in Rome who was far better known than Paul, and who was the reason that Paul was in prison. The emperor, Nero, ruled with an iron fist.

Nero was a gifted builder, a powerful ruler, and an evil, godless man. Nero had spent Rome's fortunes on his grand building projects. He spent more money than he could bring in with taxes, so he kept increasing Roman citizens' taxes. Under Nero as well as other Roman emperors, Nero attempted to appease Rome by offering a multitude of welfare projects. He would feed much of Rome daily with free bread. I often wonder if this might be part of the meaning when Jesus said, *"Man shall not live by bread alone but by every word that comes out of the mouth of God"* (Matthew 4:4). Was Jesus discouraging Roman citizens from relying on the welfare of Rome for their sustenance? I also wonder about the verse where Jesus said, *"Give us this day our daily bread"* (Matthew 6:11). Was he reminding us to rely on God's daily provisions instead of the welfare of Rome?

Nero was not the best husband, we can be assured, as he murdered two of his wives (Octavia, and Poppaea Sabina) and his own mother (Agrippina the younger). You dare not cross Nero who was more than happy to offer a show of his force and authority over life and death.

At this time in history, Rome stood alone in building projects and splendor over all of the earth. Rome ruled the known world at that time, just as the second chapter of Daniel describes, Rome was the center of the world. In fact, there are many who feel that when Jesus said that His disciples would be witnesses of Him unto the uttermost ends of the earth, that meant Rome because Rome ruled all.

In Bible prophecy, the Bible measures time before and up to the kingdom of God by the duration of four world empires, Babylon, Persia, Greece, and then Rome. Then we see the kingdom of God shattering all of the kingdoms of the earth. We know so little about this at this time as this simply has not been revealed (reference Daniel chapter 2).

Babylon was conquered by Persia. Persia was conquered by the Greeks.

The Greeks were conquered by the Romans. Rome was never conquered. Rome slowly deteriorated over a thousand-year period of history.

Nero was reigning during Paul's day at the zenith of Rome's power and glory. Nero had started another ambitious building project and was struggling to get funds to cover it. He needed more real estate for his projects. Mysteriously a fire broke out near the Circus Maximus, which was an arena that held an unbelievable 250,000 people to watch the chariot races. In a few days, 70 percent of Rome had burned to the ground. The citizens were devastated, and many blamed Nero, thinking that Nero was behind the fire in order to get the real estate he needed for his projects.

Nero needed a scapegoat on which to blame the problems of Rome. It is about this time that he decided to blame the many crises on the Roman landscape on the new Christians who lived in Rome. In this present day, governing leaders frequently blame their ineptitude on the opposing party, or on another group of people. This must be the dark side of human nature.

Nero began to round up all the Christians that he could find, including Paul. Many Christians were crucified on crosses and doused with a flammable oil, which lit the nights and streets of Rome with the bodies of believers. To the amusement of the crowds, Nero would send believers to their deaths by the mouths of lions. In 2 Timothy, we find that Paul gives thanks and says that he was spared from the mouth of the lion. This was most likely not a metaphor. Paul was spared literally from the mouths of lions in the Colosseum.

2 Timothy 4:17, NIV: *"But the Lord stood at my side and gave me strength, so that through me the message might be fully proclaimed and all the Gentiles might hear it. And I was delivered from the lion's mouth."*

Paul wrote his last letter during the maniacal rulership of troubled Nero. Many of Paul's longtime friends had deserted him. In a way, I understand. To meet with Paul and to be identified as a Christian most likely meant a death sentence to Paul's visitors. What logical, thinking human would not be afraid to be identified with Paul as a Christian during this dark and dangerous time?

What is so profound about 2 Timothy is what Paul says and also what Paul does not say. Do you find the apostle Paul railing against Nero and Rome? Do you find him asserting his civil rights and proclaiming how much of a victim he is? Do you find Paul railing against the politics of the hour? No, you do not.

Though Paul and many of the church of that hour would lose their lives due to the persecution of Nero, in an astonishing way, instead of complaining of how unfair the politics of that hour were, Paul instead encourages Timothy to pray for all of our leaders and rulers on earth:

"I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; For kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty" (1 Timothy 2:1-2, KJV).

Paul knows his last day is coming, and he is ready for his departure, still looking for another kingdom far greater than Nero's Rome. Paul's confidence was in the coming kingdom of God, not the deteriorating Roman Empire.

The words of Jesus must surely echo in Paul's ears as Jesus taught the disciples to pray, *"Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven"* (Matthew 6:10). Paul knew these words were not just a metaphor or simply a kind sentiment.

Jesus taught us to pray for and to look for a literal establishment of God's

kingdom that would one day consume all the kingdoms and governments of men and be established from shore to shore.

As Paul wrote his last epistle in the dim light of the Mamertine prison of Rome, he did not have the luxury of time to write an exhaustive letter such as he did with the books to the Corinthians (there are actually three or possibly four books to the Corinthians, we have only two), or as he did in Romans. As he writes his last book to Timothy, the cell is cold, the light is dim, and there surely is a stench in the claustrophobic cell. He is deserted by many and is suffering loneliness. He has time to write only what really matters, only his most important words to encourage Timothy to spread the good news.

Certainly, Paul had no idea, as he struggled to write his last letter to Timothy, that he would be speaking to countless millions over a period of 2,000 years. One never knows how much God will multiply the feeble work that we faithfully perform just as Jesus fed the multitudes with very little and had more leftover than he did, to begin with.

On an interesting note, the second most sold book series in the history of the world is the Harry Potter series with an estimated 400 million books sold in total. However, it is estimated that the Bible has sold about 9 billion copies through the ages. It is impossible to keep track of how many copies of the Bible there are in print and digital copies now. God multiplied the efforts of Paul's writing in that lonely prison to over 9 billion copies!

I encourage you to read all of the short four chapters of 2 Timothy in one sitting. For the sake of brevity, we will be only expounding on a few points.

"Stir up the gift that is within you."

Paul encourages Timothy to stir up the gift that God had given him. Often our gifts that are chosen and endowed by the Holy Spirit can begin to go dormant, like the neglected embers in a wood-burning stove. When the embers begin to lose their intensity it is time to blow some oxygen into the fire and stir them up.

We can stir our gifts up through prayer, speaking in tongues, reading the Scriptures and spending time in the presence of the Lord.

Paul reminds Timothy of the gifts that he has been gifted by God. He became aware of them, and they are available to him through the laying on of the hands of the presbytery, which means "group of elders." We give thanks to the almighty God that in this very hour, in this kingdom-building hour, God has once again restored this function in the church.

No longer must children of God wander in fields of ministry that they are not called to, as they blindly look for God's clear direction for their lives and ministry. Once again, with great accuracy, when the time is right, as the Holy Spirit indicates, gifts and ministries are bestowed by the laying on of the hands of the presbytery even as it was in Paul's day.

"Therefore I remind you to stir up the gift of God which is in you through the laying on of my hands" (2 Timothy 1:6-7, NKJV).

"Neglect not the gift that is in thee, which was given thee by prophecy, with the laying on of the hands of the presbytery" (1 Timothy 4:14, KJV).

The Pattern For The Church

Paul speaks to Timothy about a simple pattern for succession; a pattern for establishing and furthering the growth and existence of the church through the ages. It is a simple pattern that Paul teaches Timothy. Once again, in this kingdom hour, we strive to follow this pattern without overcomplicating it or modifying the pattern to fit what we think is more palatable.

"And the things that you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also" (2 Timothy 2:2, NKJV).

Paul speaks much of the simple order of elders and deacons in 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy and in Titus. The simple order revealed from the very beginning was the pattern of apostolic ministry, setting elders and deacons in local assemblies, from men of their own. Paul was an apostle. Timothy and Titus shared in an apostolic ministry as apostolic deacons or helpers to Paul, and they were charged to set things in order by establishing elders in each city.

Reference scriptures:

"For this reason I left you in Crete, that you should set in order the things that are lacking, and appoint elders in every city as I commanded you" (Titus 1:5, NKJV).

"So when they had appointed elders in every church, and prayed with fasting, they commended them to the Lord in whom they had believed" (Acts 14:23, NKJV).

The truth of the scriptures is that the order of multiple elders in local assemblies is the pattern of the New Testament. Many will say that having ordinary elders is not very glamorous or entertaining for the crowds. The Bible warns us (2 Timothy 4:3) that men would, in the last days, gather for themselves teachers having itching ears. In other words, they will want hired pastors who will say what they want to hear.

There was a time at the end of the era of Judges, in the Old Testament, that Eli's sons were failing in following in the footsteps of Eli. They were immoral men. People looked at the current "order" of that day and cried out to Samuel for a king, to be like all of the other nations. Samuel warned the people that the king that they choose for themselves would cause the ears of the Lord to become deaf. God explained to Samuel that the people had not rejected Samuel, they had rejected God.

"And you will cry out in that day because of your king whom you have chosen for yourselves, and the LORD will not hear you in that day. Nevertheless the people refused to obey the voice of Samuel; and they said, 'No, but we will have a king over us, that we also may be like all the nations, and that our king may judge us and go out before us and fight our battles'"

(1 Samuel 8:18-20, NKJV).

The Heart Of Mankind In The Last Days

Paul then gives Timothy a prophetic picture of the hearts of the population in the last days as follows:

"But know this, that in the last days perilous times will come: For men will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boasters, proud, blasphemers, disobedient to parents, unthankful, unholy, unloving, unforgiving, slanderers, without self-control, brutal, despisers of good, traitors, headstrong, haughty, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, having a form of godliness but denying its power. And from such people turn away" (2 Timothy 3:1-5, NKJV)!

For this writing, we will not expound on the above scriptures other than to repeat the last statement. *"And from such people turn away."* If you find that the circle of friends that you keep pulls you into these dark areas, then they are not your friends indeed. Of such, turn away.

The Power Of The Scriptures

Paul reminds Timothy of the power of the Scriptures. There is nothing more accurate, more up-to-date, more tested, or more reliable than the Word of God. Our Bible contains 66 books, 39 Old Testament and 27 New Testament books, written by about 40 different writers over a period of 1,500 years, all pointing to the work of Jesus Christ and God's plan

for creation. How is it possible for 40 writers, over a period of 1,500 years to write in harmony and unison with one another? The answer is, there were 40 writers, but only one AUTHOR. That author was God.

Don't let anyone tell you that the Bible is an old book with old ideas. There is nothing more current than the Bible. In fact, miraculously the Bible contains past history, current day history, and recorded history of that which is to come in the future with great accuracy. Over and over again, the Bible has miraculously proven itself with prophecies fulfilled centuries after they were written.

"Preach the word! Be ready in season and out of season. Convince, rebuke, exhort, with all longsuffering and teaching. For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine, but according to their own desires, because they have itching ears, they will heap up for themselves teachers; and they will turn their ears away from the truth, and be turned aside to fables" (2 Timothy 4:2-4, NKJV).

Be Ready In Season And Out Of Season

We might often overlook the words of Paul when he said, "...be ready in season and out of season". What did he mean? In Paul's life, there were times when he was "in season," when Paul had an audience with the multitudes, such as when the brightest philosophers of the Greek empire came to hear Paul speak the message of Christ on Mars Hill in Athens in the shadow of the Parthenon (Acts 17:22). But now, under Nero, we see in a sense, Paul, "out of season." Paul no longer had much of an audience (or at least it seemed that way). Paul was alone, deserted, and his execution date was scheduled in the near future. But this is where Paul did some of his best writing. He made great use of his time. He was diligent "in season and out of season."

We must be diligent at all times in serving the Lord and in not dropping our guard. The child of God must be ready in season and out of season. Ready when things seem to be moving, and ready when God, it seems, has brought our work to a pause.

In fact, it is not up to us to decide when we are really "in season or out of season." It may have seemed that Paul was "out of season" in that dark prison writing the prison epistles. However, over nine billion copies of Paul's letter, contained in the Bible, have been circulated throughout the world since that day. Paul may have felt out of season, but God had made Paul "in season."

Paul places in his closing a verse that has been memorized and recited by the multitudes. Pause for a moment and reflect again on Paul's situation. It was a dark day for Paul. He is imprisoned, and close to execution. Many of his companions had abandoned him. The Christians in Rome were coming under heavy persecution and were being slain. Jerusalem was under siege, and in three years the temple would be destroyed. Judging by the outward appearance, it may have looked as if the gospel of the kingdom would soon come to an end.

Paul reflects over his life with no despair, no regrets, and writes:

"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Finally, there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will give to me on that Day, and not to me only but also to all who have loved His appearing" (2 Timothy 4:7-8, NKJV).

Have you fought the good fight? It is a battle. Are you fighting the good fight?

Are you continuing in the race? God has not called us to a short 100-yard dash where a man runs as fast as he can for a short distance. God is calling for spiritual marathon runners, those who will run the distance.

"Therefore we also, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight and the sin which so easily ensnares us, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us" (Hebrews 12:1, NKJV).

Have you kept the faith? Faith requires maintenance; loving, daily, consistent maintenance. A good marriage requires the same.

"But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him" (Hebrews 11:6, NKJV).

That crown of righteousness that Paul speaks of that he has received is also reserved for all those who love His appearing. ✚

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SHARON STAR

The Sharon Star is a monthly publication and mailed as a free-will offering plan. The articles within are intended for inspiration and information to those who are interested in the unfolding revelation of the Word of God.

Published by:
Global Missions Inc. in North Battleford, Saskatchewan, Canada.

The Sharon Star is found online at:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/sharon-star

Publications Mail Agreement 40012206

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